

**UNIT
7**

POEMS

UNIT 14 POEMS

ABOU BEN ADHEM

James Henry Leigh Hunt (1784–1859) lived during the late 18th and early 19th centuries. He was an English poet, essayist, and journalist. He was known for his involvement in literary criticism and his bold stance against political figures, which led to his imprisonment. Despite this, he continued to inspire young poets and contributed significantly to Romantic poetry. His poem *Abou Ben Adhem* reflects themes of love, kindness, and the value of humanity over religious devotion.

Abou Ben Adhem (may his tribe increase)
Awoke one night from a deep dream of peace,
And saw, within the moonlight in his room,
Making it rich, and like a lily in bloom,
An Angel writing in a book of gold.

Exceeding peace had made Ben Adhem bold,
And to the presence in the room he said,
"What writest thou?"— The vision raised its head,
And, with a look made of all sweet accord,
Answered, "The names of those who love the Lord."

"And is mine one?" said Abou. "Nay, not so."
Replied the Angel. Abou spoke more low,
But cheerily still, and said, "I pray thee, then,
Write me as someone who loves his fellow humans."
The angel wrote, and vanished. The next night,

It came again with a great wakening light,
And showed the names whom love of God had blessed,
And lo! Ben Adhem's name led all the rest.

Answer the following questions:

Literal Understanding

1. Who was Abou Ben Adhem?
2. What did Abou Ben Adhem see in his room one night?
3. What was the angel writing in the book of gold?
4. How did Abou Ben Adhem react when his name was not on the list?
5. What did the angel do when Abou asked to be written as someone who loves his fellow men?

Interpretation & Analysis

6. What does the phrase "may his tribe increase" suggest?
7. Why do you think Abou Ben Adhem was "bold" when speaking to the angel?
8. What does the poem suggest about love for God vs. love for fellow humans?
9. What is the significance of the angel returning the next night?
10. What lesson does the poem convey about kindness and compassion?

Critical Thinking & Discussion

11. Do you think loving fellow humans is equal to loving God? Why or why not?
12. How does this poem encourage selflessness and generosity?
13. If you were in Abou Ben Adhem's place, how would you react to the angel's response?
14. Can you relate this poem to real-life situations where kindness is more valued than religious devotion?
15. How does the ending of the poem emphasize the importance of good deeds?

THE DAFFODILS

William Wordsworth (1770–1850), a leading figure of the Romantic era, spent his life between the 18th and 19th centuries. He was one of the greatest Romantic poets of England. He was deeply inspired by nature and believed in using simple language to express deep emotions. His poetry often focused on the beauty of the natural world and its impact on human emotions. His famous poem 'The Daffodils' captures the joy and inspiration that nature brings, emphasizing the lasting impact of a beautiful experience.

I wandered lonely as a cloud
That floats on high o'er vales and hills,
When all at once I saw a crowd,
A host, of golden daffodils;
Beside the lake, beneath the trees,
Fluttering and dancing in the breeze.

Continuous as the stars that shine
And twinkle on the milky way,
They stretched in never-ending line
Along the margin of a bay:
Ten thousand saw I at a glance,
Tossing their heads in sprightly dance.

The waves beside them danced; but they
Outdid the sparkling waves in glee:
A poet could not but be gay,
In such a jocund company!^[1]
I gazed – and gazed – but little thought
What wealth the show to me had brought.

For oft when on my couch I lie
In vacant or in pensive mood,
They flash upon that inward eye
Which is the bliss of solitude;
And then my heart with pleasure fills,
And dances with the daffodils.

¹ **jocund company:** cheerful group

Answer the following questions:

Literal Understanding

1. Who is the poet of The Daffodils?
2. Where does the poet see the daffodils?
3. How are the daffodils described in the poem?
4. What does the poet compare the daffodils to?
5. What does the poet mean by "a host of golden daffodils"?
6. What effect do the daffodils have on the poet when he recalls them later?

Interpretation & Analysis

7. How does the poet's mood change after seeing the daffodils?
8. Why does the poet compare the daffodils to stars in the Milky Way?
9. What does the phrase "jocund company" mean in the poem?
10. What is the significance of the phrase "bliss of solitude"?

Critical Thinking & Discussion

11. How does the poet express his deep connection with nature?
12. Why do you think the poet continues to remember the daffodils even after he has left the scene?
13. Do you think nature has the same impact on modern people as it did on Wordsworth? Why or why not?
14. If you were in the poet's place, how would you feel upon seeing such a scene?
15. Can you relate a personal experience where nature influenced your emotions?

THE MILLER OF THE DEE

Charles Mackay (1814-1889), a Victorian-era poet and journalist, lived through the 19th century. He was a Scottish poet, journalist, and songwriter, known for his uplifting and moralistic themes. His songs and poems often celebrated hard work, honesty, and the value of a simple, content life. The Miller of the Dee contrasts wealth and happiness, showing that true joy comes not from riches, but from peace of mind, love, and self-sufficiency.

There dwelt a miller hale and bold,
Beside the river Dee;
He worked and sang from morn to night,
No lark more blithe than he,
And this the burden of his song
For ever used to be,
"I envy nobody, no, not I,
And nobody envies me!"

"Thou'rt wrong my friend!" said old King Hal,
"Thou'rt wrong as wrong can be;
For, could my heart be light as thine,
I'd gladly change with thee,
And tell me now, what makes thee sing
With voice so loud and free,
While I am sad, though I am the king,
Beside the river Dee?"

The miller smiled and doffed his cap;
"I earn my bread," quoth he,
"I love my wife, I love my friend,
I love my children three;
I owe no penny I cannot pay;
I thank the river Dee,
That turns the mill that grinds the corn
To feed my bales and me."

"Good friend!" said Hal, and sighed the while,
"Farewell, and happy be;
But say no more, if thou'dst say true,
That no man envies thee.
Thy mealy cap is worth my crown,
Thy mill my kingdom's fee^[1];
Men like you are the pride of England.
O'miller of the Dee."

1 "fee" here means "worth" or "value."

Answer the following questions:

Literal Understanding

1. Who is the poet of The Miller of the Dee?
2. Where does the miller live?
3. What does the miller do all day?
4. What is the miller's song about?
5. What does King Hal say about the miller's happiness?
6. How does the miller describe his life?
7. Why does the king envy the miller?
8. What does the king finally realize at the end of the poem?

Interpretation & Analysis

9. What does the miller's contentment with his life suggest about true happiness?
10. Why does the king, despite having wealth and power, feel unhappy?
11. What message does the poem convey about wealth and happiness?
12. How does the river Dee contribute to the miller's well-being?
13. What does the phrase "Thy mealy cap is worth my crown" mean?

Critical Thinking & Discussion

14. Do you agree that simple joys bring more happiness than wealth? Why or why not?
15. How does the poem relate to modern society, where people seek wealth and power?
16. If you had to choose between a simple happy life and a powerful but stressful life, which would you choose and why?
17. How does this poem reflect the difference between material success and inner peace?
18. In today's world, can a person live like the miller and still be happy? Why or why not?